The Body and the Possible Soul in Digital Ekphrastic Poetry

Jolene Mathieson
University of Hamburg

Abstract New media technologies have inaugurated the most recent and important shift in our understanding of word-image relations. While seminal studies of new media poetry (Funkhouser 2012; Hayles 2006, 2008) and its potentially ekphrastic properties (Lindhé 2013) have been published in recent years, the close relationship between digital poetry and ekphrasis has yet to be convincingly theorized. This article focuses on new media poetry and the digital strategies it utilizes in the ekphrastic remediation of art images. Digital media may be unique in its ability to create highly immersive environments that more readily activate a holistically embodied and dialogical experience for the reader in represencing images, but digital ekphrastic praxis also exploits its multimodal, polysemiotic possibilities to critically reflect on the nature of the digital image and its relations to material ontology. This critique, and its emphasis on both representational and experiential reasoning, primarily takes the form of lyrical meditations on the material and immaterial realities of code, of computer-mediated poetry, of images, and of human-computer interaction. The result of these poetic meditations is a type of ekphrasis that is willfully metaphysical in tone and content, as will be evidenced via a close reading of two digital ekphrastic poems: Deena Larsen's "Carving in Possibilities" (2001) and Harry Giles's "Photo of Maud Wagner" (2013).

Keywords digital poetry, intermediation, metaphysics, dynamic heterarchy, digital ekphrasis

Poetics Today 39:2 (June 2018) DOI 10.1215/03335372-4324505
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Sui Generis: Digital Poetry, Multimodality, and Image Production

Digital poetry is endowed with a generous degree of intermedial playfulness and generic ambivalence. Its setting is dynamic and ambient. And it possesses a *sui generis* ability to create highly particularized and immersive environments capable of activating embodied, dialogical experiences for the reader—all of which points to digital poetry's potential as an especially poignant and fertile medium for assessing and remediating the infinitely reproducible and malleable digital art image. The extent to which the digital regime tends to be conceptualized, structured, and experienced in primarily visual terms has been a focal point for crucial debates in new media studies (see Bolter and Grusin 1999: 23; Hansen 2006; Mitchell 2015), and further signals the importance of visual technologies as viable technogenic agents of sociobiological meaning that actively shape how humans interact and coevolve with images (see Hayles 2012). Additionally, the ubiquity of digital graphics, pictorial media, and online image archives and hosting platforms highlights the necessity for a digital lyrical form capable of mediating contemporary aesthetic consciousness. As such, a digital poetry of ekphrasis seems not only intuitively compelling but even axiomatic or tautological. The close relationship between digital poetry and ekphrasis, however, remains theoretically elusive despite the recent publication of seminal studies of new media poetry (Funkhouser 2012; Hayles 2006, 2008) and its potentially ekphrastic properties (Lindhé 2013). There are several complex, interconnected reasons for this, the most fundamental being a question of genre and the messy theoretical consequences that so often accompany definition and classification.

Digital poetry is predicated on code and computation for its creation, displayed on electronic screens for its consumption, and, crucially, comprised of elements from linguistic, audio, gestural, spatial, and visual semiotic modes for its signification. Practitioners and theorists of digital poetry are careful to foreground its literariness by pointing to its origins in concrete and visual poetry, found poetry, automatic writing, and other experimental forms of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, as well as oral and slam poetry (see Funkhouser 2008; Wardrip-Fruin 2008). Yet born of computer experimentation and genetically related to performance, computer, and interactive media art (see Block et al. 2004: 13–17), digital poetry's *raison d'être* is to realize technically the more abstract premises of its literary predecessors. A digital poem is a "poem" because its literary impetus is to poetically exploit the disparate spaces between linguistic and audio, gestural, spatial, and visual semiotic systems. However, by including video files, sound files, and/or generative and interactive features, it is also a multimodal, interstitial event that can be felt, heard, seen, and navigated (see Funkhouser 2008).

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This high degree of polysemy, multimodality, and sensory richness is what renders digital poetry so uniquely seductive in the context of ekphrasis, but also so problematic. Ekphrasis, a notoriously slippery term in it its own right, is a mode of poetics that is also intermedial, but regardless whether it is understood in its ancient or more contemporary senses, it invariably functions via the medium of language. The single feature common to all its competing definitions and chaotic results is its reliance on indexing verbal or lexemic units to produce sensuous effects of representation or of image-making within the mind of the reader. What distinguishes a digital ekphrasis from its more traditional relatives in rhetoric and print is that it can and does exploit a type of visuality based on generating and mapping images external to the mind. The function of ekphrasis within the digital regime is thus dependent on an individual poem's operating procedures and lyrical strategies for configuring and arbitrating its verbally produced endogenous images and externally generated digital images. The ekphrastic quality of a digital poem is contingent on the specific ways in which such procedures, which necessarily operate on both a representational and a visceral-experiential level, make literally and metaphorically visible images that are not there and make absent those that are present. As I show in the following, the complex, multilevel relations between absence and presence, between the physical and the transcendent, between agent and actant are metaphysical concepts that a digital poetry of ekphrasis will need to address at the level of content but which will also be made manifest at the material level.[1] Acknowledging the relative obscurity and tricky conceptualization of a digital poetry of ekphrasis, I first attempt to conceptually or theoretically link digital poetry with ekphrasis, and in a second step, I offer a reading of two poems, Deena Larsen's "Carving in Possibilities" (2001) and Harry Giles's "Photo of Maud Wagner" (2013). These two poems are compelling examples of a contemporary material practice that is currently exploring and utilizing a number of polysemiotic strands to recreate, reappropriate, or represent the visual art image in a verbalized, digital form, and can be understood as digital ekphrasis.

Conceptual Linking: Digital Poetry and Ekphrasis

As Cecilia Lindhé has pointed out, most new media theorists and word-image scholars would altogether repudiate the existence of ekphrasis in digital

1. I use the term *actant* to refer to an agent that is mutually determined and acted upon by another agent. As all agents are in some sense also actants, the agent-actant relationship is codependent and relational. For an in-depth discussion on actants in actor-network-theory, see Bruno Latour (2005: 53–55).

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poetry or would otherwise argue for its terminological redundancy (2013: n.p., par. 11). Marie-Laure Ryan, for example, diagnoses ekphrasis as almost antediluvian in light of multimedia systems and their complex polysemy. Arguing that "some types of thought are better served by expressive resources that do not involve discrete and arbitrary symbols," Ryan claims that in virtual reality (VR) "there will be no need for ekphrasis—the verbal description of a visual artwork—because the system will encompass all forms of representation, action and signification. The multisensory will also be the omnisemiotic" (2015 [2001]: 46). W. J. T. Mitchell, too, insists on the monosemiotic or solitary role language plays in the case of ekphrasis. In a 2007 essay reissued and slightly revised in 2015's *Image Science*, he revisits his position that, in ekphrasis,

> the visual, graphic, or plastic object, is never made visible or tangible *except* by way of the medium of language. One might call ekphrasis a form of nesting without touching or suturing, a kind of action-at-distance between two rigorously separated sensory and semiotic tracks, one that requires completion in the mind of the reader. This is why poetry remains the most subtle, agile master-medium of the *sensus communis*, no matter how many spectacular multimedia inventions are devised to assault our collective sensibilities. (Mitchell 2015: 132)

As a "multimedia invention," digital poetry would thus be excluded from the ekphrastic enterprise. But as an interstitial form nestled in the often dissonant spaces between modalities, it can and frequently does distend and augment the gaps intervening among the haptic, the aural, the seen, and the read. The suturing ambitions or abilities of television and other multimedia assumed by Mitchell will not be applicable in a blanket fashion to all or even most digital poetry. Digital poetry is a highly heterogeneous amalgam of forms, methods, and media that include but are not limited to VR poems and other types of interactive poetry, hypertext poetry, video poetry, digital sound poetry, kinetic and animated poetry, code poetry, poetry generators, and other fringe and hybrid forms (Funkhouser 2008: n.p.). Further, as Talan Memmott aptly observes, digital poetics resists taxonomy, thanks to what he calls "the transitive aspects of its elements, and the transactive quality of its applications" (2006: 304); thus to speak meaningfully of digital poetry in the context of ekphrasis requires a vigilant reading of individual case studies carefully positioned in relation to each other.

The "transitive" and "transactive" features mentioned by Memmott are what lend the genre its vigor and hybridity. But they also indirectly reference the digital poem's ontological nature as a code-object, as that which is accessed via a user's interface with an electronic screen but is not permanently recorded or inscribed by the material artifacts presenting it. Hidden or

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ensconced within both the material hardware and digital software that mechanically animate it, the code-object is both an agent and an actant that directs but also embodies the case-specific data structures and looping, random but deterministic inputs and outputs from hardware, software, and user, so that upon animation each individual digital poem emerges in real time as its own object but also as its own performative event. In *Electronic Literature: New Horizons for the Literary*, N. Katherine Hayles patiently and luminously describes how this emergent event results from what she terms "dynamic heterarchy" or multilevel complexity comprised of "second-, third-, and *n*-level emergences" that move both horizontally and vertically to "continuously inform and mutually determine each other" (2008: 45). This multilevel complexity is, not surprisingly, a feature of the cognizant, embodied user. But it is also, crucially, a feature of the computer-mediated text. The computer-mediated text is characterized by Hayles (drawing on Strickland 2006) as (1) multimodal; (2) "layered" through "cascading processes of interpretation" on the part of language tags, programming languages, codes, and strings, much of which is looping, often recursive, and invisible to the user when generating the text seen on screen; and (3) a realization of "fractured temporality," denoting the degree to which mechanical hardware, computer settings, and mouse function affect loading times and other temporal features that "fracture time" in idiosyncratic, agentic ways (ibid.: 163–64).

The entangled nexus constituted by the dynamic interactions of the embodied user and the computer-mediated text, then, forms the next level of complexity, which Hayles labels "intermediation" (ibid.: 51–52). The concept of intermediation stresses the material agency of code objects and computer systems as well as of the human body, so that meaning-making capabilities are equally distributed as feedback and feedforward loops. Hayles's notion of intermediation thus effectively mitigates Mark B. Hansen's subordination of technology to the body in his highly influential work on immersion and embodiment—key concepts in much recent theorizing on ekphrasis, especially in the field of neuroaesthetics (see Starr 2013). Hansen censures digital technology's privileging of ocular modes of visualization as well as its uncanny ability to mimic or create image-objects of simulacra in which representation and referent collapse together so completely that such objects are no longer representable but merely haunting manifestations of the hyperreal's *horror vacui*, or what he calls "the referential void" (Hansen 2004a: 600). In light of the subsistent nature of the digital, that is its sense of being without existing, Hansen sees a rigorously phenomenological account of embodiment as the only possibility for rehabilitating meaning in human-computer interaction (see Hansen 2004b; Hayles 2008: 102–13, 179–86). Hayles's critique of this position rightly denounces its readiness to ignore the

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material reality of the digital, arguing that "although it is true that digital technologies can create objects for which there is no original . . . , the technology itself is perfectly representable" (2008: 180).

In his *Visual Art: From Illusion to Immersion*, Oliver Grau, too, emphasizes the primary role of the body in ascribing and relaying meaning in new media. Grau understands immersion as a sense of "presence (an impression suggestive of 'being there'), which can be further enhanced through interaction with apparently 'living' environments in 'real time'" (2003: 7) and which is "characterized by diminishing critical distance to what is shown and increasing emotional involvement in what is happening" (ibid.: 13). This is achieved via "sound, tactile and haptic impressions, and thermoreceptive and even kinaesthetic sensations" (ibid.: 15). "Literary immersions," which appeal to the imagination through words, Grau argues, "differ fundamentally from the visual strategies of immersion in the virtual reality of the computer" (ibid.: 15). Although this is undoubtedly the case due to the interiorized versus exteriorized production of images discussed above, several features shared between the two serve as the conceptual segue for Cecilia Lindhé's rather provocative attempt to link classical ekphrasis with digital media (2013: n.p.). Lindhé points to Ruth Webb's influential definition of classical ekphrasis as "a dynamic mode of writing thought to have an immediate impact on its audience" (Webb 1999: 17) and which "leads one around (*periege-matikos*) bringing the subject matter vividly (*enargos*) before the eyes" (ibid.: 11). With respect to Hansen's prioritizing of embodiment, Lindhé argues that "digital literature and art align with this concept of ekphrasis, especially in the way that its rhetorical meaning is about effect, immediacy, aurality, and tactility" (2013: n.p., par. 2). Grounding her argumentation in the analogous relationship between perception in VR and ekphrasis, Lindhé writes:

> Just as Grau describes the characteristics of VR and immersion as a space of possibility and impossibility, the ancient ekphrasis is dependent on an "as-if-presentness." In Quintilian's description of *enargeia* an "as if" (*quam si*) always figures: *enargeia* is about illusion and takes place in an ongoing tension between presence and absence [Webb 2009: 168–69]. It is this oscillation or process of visualization that is of interest here, not the representation of the object. (2013: n.p., par. 13)

While I am quite sympathetic with the overall sentiment here, in order to avoid the terminological and conceptual redundancy rightly feared by Jay David Bolter and Richard Grusin so long ago (1999: 45) and to further capture the technical issues central to digital literature, it is still necessary to create a more robust, second-order linking of ekphrasis with digital poetry. Webb has shown how ekphrasis was one of the means by which a pupil was taught to write and speak in a manner that exhibited a high degree of verbal-

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visual mimesis (Webb 2009: 18–22). It was a means of producing images in the mind of the listener but also taught the listener how to imaginatively and visually engage with a text and to be visually and emotionally transported to the scene being described. As Webb theorizes, in ekphrasis, "words do not directly represent their subjects, but are attached to a mental representation of that subject" (ibid.: 128), which means that rhetoricians conceived of ekphrasis as a dialogic in which the mind of the listener is an active agent in the process of receiving, composing, and engaging with mental images activated via the speaker's agentic use of rhetorical strategies, mimetic cues, and semantic frames (ibid.: 18–22). The dialogic here, though, is a human-to-human interaction in which both participants are agents but also actants within the visualization process, where the visualized object is an individuated, subjective, emergent realization that in each instantiation necessarily differs. Linking the dialogical nature of ekphrasis to digital media would, it seems to me, thus require Hayles's concept of intermediation as that which logically, both metaphorically and literally, corresponds to the complex, idiosyncratic agency-actant relationship between systems and participants. As Richard Powers so passionately argued in "Seeming and Being," his essay on the impossible paradox of virtual reality, "the more advanced the media, the higher the level of mediation" (2000: n.p.). In other words, while immediacy and immersion may give the impression of a reality that is directly accessed, it is produced via mediation procedures that rely on representable structures as well as structures of representation. The more advanced the media, the more it relies on such structures and the more it relies on intermediation. The beauty of conceptualizing a digital ekphrasis in light of intermediation is that on various levels and to varying degrees it would robustly accommodate rhetorical ekphrasis and its emphasis on immersion as theorized by Webb (2009), but also ekphrasis understood as representation and meta-representation, as theorized by James Heffernan (1993) and Mitchell (1986, 1994). Because of the dynamic heterarchy of digital poetry, immersion via visualization and the representation of visual media are inextricably linked. It is not that they are indistinguishable, but that they are invariably entangled.

A poetics of digital ekphrasis would thus be a type of poetics aware of and able to account for both the processes of visualization as well as their infinite desire for and embodiment of the representation of visual media and vice versa. It would be a type of poetics able to endorse both the cultural or metaphorical power of the living image as well as the technical agency of the enlivened digital image. It would also be a poetics deft at pursuing its multimodal, polysemiotic possibilities to critically reflect on and maybe even subvert the nature of the (de-)materialized digital image and its relation to

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material ontology. Finally, it would be a poetics that is both the result of and the instigator of intermediation. This, in turn, means that a poetics of digital ekphrasis will be very complex—thematically, structurally, and materially.

To Enliven Is to Kill Is to Enliven Is to Kill (Ad Infinitum): Metaphysical Recursion in Deena Larsen's "Carving in Possibilities"

Deena Larsen's now canonical "Carving in Possibilities" (2001) is a time-based hypertext poem comprised of written text, as well as visual, audio, animated, and kinetic elements. These elements are compressed into a Shockwave Flash file, which means that the user cannot access the poem's source code and that its specific formats remain hermetic. The opening sequence of the poem displays a blurred, pixelated, close-up image of Michelangelo's colossal statue of David housed in the Academia Gallery Museum in Florence, onto which the title "Carving in possibilities" is superimposed. Discretely placed under the title as a full sentence are the instructions "Mouse slowly to carve out your existence." Located to the user's right is a button with

Figure 1 Screenshot of title page, Deena Larsen's "Carving in Possibilities." www.collection.eliterature.org/1/works/larsen__carving_in_possibilities.html. Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivs 2.5 License

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further instructions, "click / to start"; upon mousing over it, but not clicking on it, the line "And remember where you put your ghosts" appears, as is shown in figure 1.

The poem's title page is accompanied by a musical theme meant to invoke the eerie soundtracks of 1950s sci-fi films. It disappears after fourteen seconds but remains a ghostly, vaguely visual presence in the mind of the user. Through the progressive aspect of the present tense used in the title, the imperative voice in the remaining text fragments, and the haunting qualities of its soundtrack, this title page frames the user's participation as one of active responsibility. While the music is threatening in tone, the linguistic text directs and firmly coaxes the user to enter its portal. Clicking on the start button allows the user to metaphorically enter the gates of Florence and access what is the same pixelated, close-up image of David accompanied by the same soundtrack, but now overlayed with invisible hotspots that are then triggered upon mouseover. Each hotspot activates three simultaneous but different semiotic modes or responses:

1. A single color-coded line of embedded or hidden poetic text emerges and remains as long as the pointer hovers, as seen in figures 3 and 4. In total, it would appear that there exist upwards of fifteen different color and typeface combinations varying in point scales that loosely denote bundles of thematic content and/or speaker situations. It is sometimes the case that the pointer will cover the text upon mouseover, rendering it difficult to read.
2. A sharp, 8-bit sound connotative of both gunfire and the striking of a hammer on marble is heard. The quality and duration of the sound effects, in combination with the soundtrack, reference both the aesthetic and generic conventions of classic point-and-click adventure games from the 1980s and 90s, especially Ron Gilbert's *Maniac Mansion* and its playful haunted-house narrative based on intertexts from horror films in which a limited number of endings are possible depending on user inputs (see Gilbert 1987).
3. The image of David's face is metaphorically carved as its resolution and color scheme become a grade sharper. While this is a time-based piece, the poem does not end until the user has completed ca. 30–40 triggers, at which point David's face will become entirely focused and thus fully "carved." The combinations of lines are linked in physical proximity so that thematic understanding emerges via the user's navigation of the mouse, but are organized in a nonlinear manner, which, in combination with the user's individual decisions regarding the speed and direction of mouse movement, means that the total reading will be

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made up of all the different performances and will vary from case to case (Funkhouser 2012: 72–77). As seen in figure 2, once the ghostly image of David is rendered completely absent and the focused image entirely present, the poem ends and an exit button appears to the lower right and a "sculpt again" button appears on the lower left, in which a hotspot for the line "for another reality" is embedded.

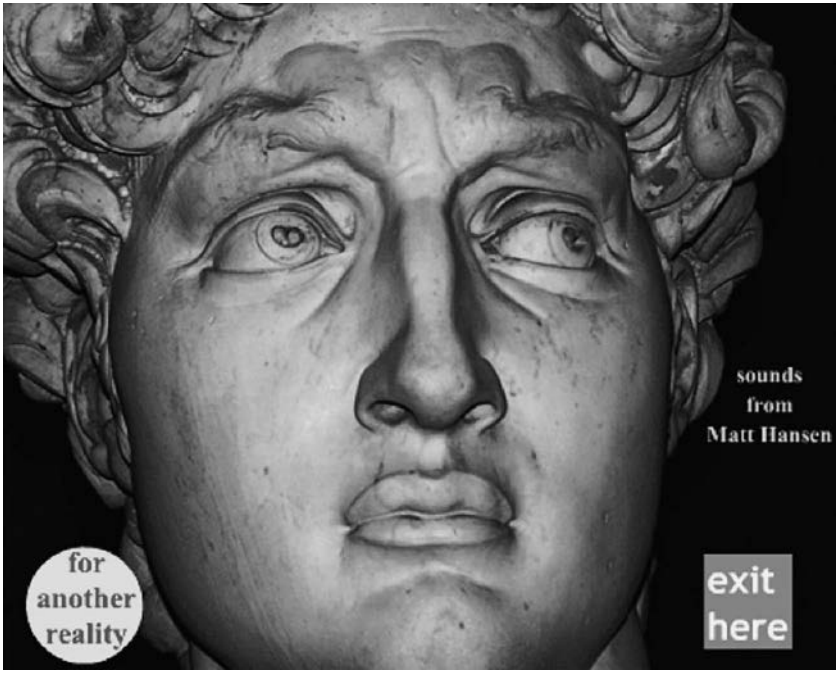

Figure 2 Screenshot of closing page, Deena Larsen's "Carving in Possibilities." www.collection.eliterature.org/1/works/larsen__carving_in_possibilities.html. Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivs 2.5 License

So while the poem may appear to end, it actively desires the user to continue on to a second, third, and nth number of runs, of which each is a new reality not yet experienced by the user. The degree of multimodal complexity and recombinant flux in this poem, and in contradistinction to the video games it quotes, renders an exhaustive reading utterly impossible. And due to the emergent reading experience in each run, a critical interpretation of the poem will in every case be only a haunting fragment of its potential textual totality, a hermeneutic manifestation of the ghost in the machine. Nonetheless, as C. T. Funkhouser points out, by situating specific lines of poetic text within "the same area of the screen as the start button, which every

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viewer must activate," comprehensible packets of thematic content are revealed in intervals determined by the users (2012: 72). These packets may appear in varying combinations for each run, but are deterministically designed so that meaning can be presented in just a few runs. As such, following Funkhouser and his nomenclature (ibid.: 73), I provide a transcription. The single slash indicates a line break, the double slash indicates a link break, and the numbers added by me denote a link of poetry.

Run 1:

I do not know my dream / in your reality //	1
I saw precisely / what the stone was / meant to be //	2
Others had tried the stone / before me //	3
He stands poised to / strike //	4
When was it yours? //	5
He stands poised to / strike //	6
echoes of waiting hordes //	7
When was this his thought? //	8
When is stone stone? //	9
When is real real? //	10
Eyes watchful . . . the / neck of a bull . . . hands / of a killer . . . //	11
of a single reality //	12
Be honest. //	13
of a single reality //	14
echoes of fig leaf / titters and / scowls of shame //	15
Muscles resting. / Ready. //	16
I am the waiting stone. //	17
unknowable //	18
Knowing what you know now //	19
Or do they inhabit 10,000 possible worlds / as real to them as ours is to us? //	20
Can we feel it in the depth / or only in the carved shadows? //	21
perfections //	22
I am everything you //	23
imperfections //	24
Does your David lie / only on the surface / of your polished stone?	25
perceptions //	26
to keep youth in taut unmoving motion //	27
It's the same stone. //	28
no matter who inhabits it //	29
Is it the stone / or is it the name / that gives life? //	30
Who breathed life into whom? //	31
Which ghosts are you hiding from? //	32

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Figure 3 A line of text from Run 1 in Deena Larsen's "Carving in Possibilities." www.collection.eliterature.org/1/works/larsen__carving_in_possibilities.html. Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivs 2.5 License

Run 2:

Do you care who is telling you this now? // 33
The gods had taken / everything we had had / long before. // 34
A baby cried in the hot, still air. // 35
We saw the stone resting / in his dry palms. / We were afraid. // 36
We waited as the wind / blew in our faces. / We did not know where / to run. // 37
Our fate was carved / in the jagged shards / of his stone. // 38
Would you have stared / up into his eyebrows as // 39
Knowing what you know now // 40
unknowable // 41
I am the waiting stone. // 42
Muscles resting. Ready. // 43
I am everything you // 44
perfections // 45
imperfections // 46
to see you as God // 47
under the shelter / of impossibility // 48
I am the waiting stone. // 49

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indivisible // 50
I could feel him . . . under me / Watching . . . as I chipped away . . . // 51
Who he was depended on the / sinews outside the stone. // 52
Or was there, always and ever, / only one David for you? // 53
Did they mock your vision / with their special possibilities? // 54
A solitary David locked / in the one rejected stone // 55
The decision made. // 56
In the end . . . it is only / absence that matters. // 57
It is the ground . . . not the figure / the space . . . not the stone // 58
Is it the stone / or is it the name / that gives life? // 59
It's the same stone. // 60
Is this what you want / to call back as real? 61
It's the same stone. // 62
no matter who inhabits it // 63
only what inhabits / the surface of the atoms / changes // 64
ancient bodies / compressed / into calcite structures // 65
no matter who inhabits it // 66
no matter who inhabits it // 67
heated from the core out — / bones melted into / unrecognizable shapes // 68
Did they dance for you / just out of reach? // 69
Is it the stone / or is it the name / that gives life? // 70
leaving only outline // 71
conceptions // 72
Does your David lie / only on the surface / of your polished stone? // 73
of their reality // 74
of a single reality // 75
Be honest. // 76
echoes of fig leaf / titters and / scowls of shame // 77
I am nothing you k // 78
I am everything you // 79
Can we feel it in the depths / or only in the carved shadows? // 80

Run 3:

We saw the stone resting / in his dry palms. / We were afraid. // 81
invisible // 82
invisible // 83
invisible // 84
Are they all here now? // 85
What if we could hold them all / here now? // 86
What makes your polished stone different / from one tumbled in a riverbed? 87
Or could they ignore / your pounding? // 88
Or did they answer your knock / upon their being? // 89
Who breathed life into whom? // 90

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Did they tell you their names? // 91
Who breathed life into whom? // 92
I am the waiting stone. // 93
I cut away everything / that wasn't needed. // 94
Did they furrow / impossible brows / and decline your offers? // 95
It's the same stone. // 96
to keep youth in taut unmoving motion // 97
can you distinguish the atoms of your soul / from the stone? // 98
It's the same stone. // 99
no matter who inhabits it // 100
It's the same stone. // 101
It will be the same stone / long after his face / is worn away. // 102
no matter who inhabits it // 103
ancient bodies / compressed / into calcite structures // 104
heated from the core out — / bones melted into / unrecognizable shapes // 105
The wind blowing against me // 106
nothing during // 107
Is that what he told you? // 108
How do you know this David / did not lie? // 109
Did they keep / you company in / polyphonic harmony? // 110
When was his thought? // 111
When is stone stone? // 112
of a single reality // 113
of their reality // 114
Does your David lie / only on the surface / of your polished stone? // 115
imperfections // 116
to see you as God // 117

When taken together, these three runs, and figures 3 and 4, present a highly entangled and conceptually blended narrative of, on one "side," Michelangelo carving the statue of David, Michelangelo's thoughts on the metaphysical repercussions of creating life from apparently dead matter, David's thoughts on being carved and encased into a rigid form by Michelangelo as well as the viewers' interactions with the statue as they visit the gallery, with, on the other "side," the biblical account of David pointing and throwing the stone that killed Goliath, the thoughts and actions of the crowd watching, as well as the stone's metaphysical dread at being implicated in the killing process. This, in turn, is augmented by the speaker of the poem. As intermediated agent-actants, we are in some sense the speaker of the poem although we are being addressed. We are thus responsible but also made responsible for exerting linguistic or verbal agency in the processes of making present and absent. This is especially made evident with the reference to video games, in which a player must often make decisions, such as

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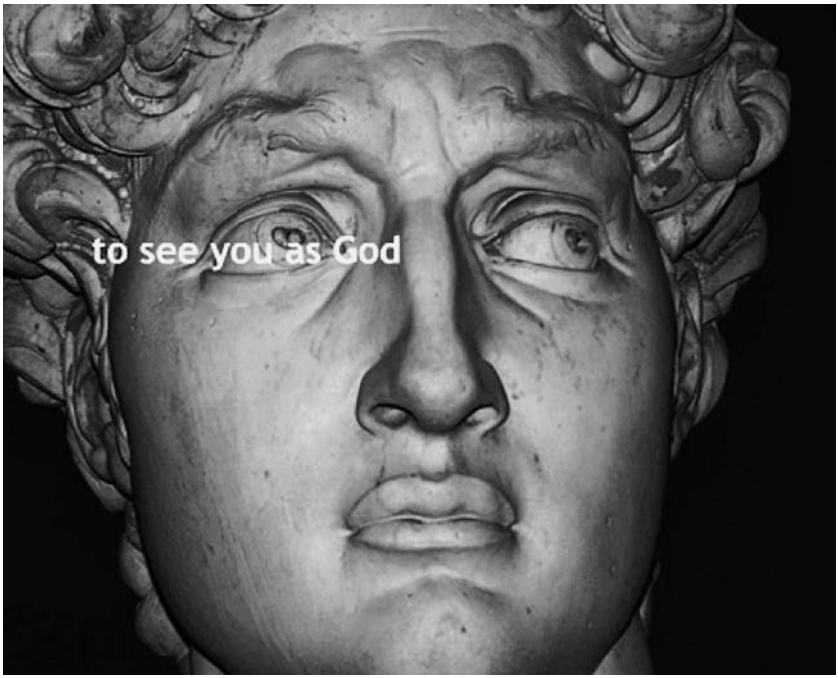

Figure 4 A line of text from Run 3 in Deena Larsen's "Carving in Possibilities." www.collection.eliterature.org/1/works/larsen__carving_in_possibilities.html. Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivs 2.5 License

killing a rival or overcoming a threat, in order to win the game. While it may seem that killing in a virtual setting is not actual killing, the metaphysical paradox of the material agency of the code-object and its mechanical processes of animation in conjunction with the aleatory or contingent inputs from the embodied user is such that killing and enlivening become uncannily intertwined. The layering and levels of conflation taking place through the various speakers and grammatical inversions then extend this paradox to the creation and representation of the statue of David, where we become the sculptor giving birth to David's representation, which, made of marble, becomes both the stone as well as the boy, David, who kills Goliath. David, the statue, is ensouled but capable of desouling. Thus, as we sculpt David, we kill Goliath; but in an act of recursion, as we kill Goliath, we enliven David. In light of the poem's title page warning the user to "remember where you put your ghosts" as well as its spectral soundtrack, we become increasingly aware that as an embodied, intermediated agent-actant, we thus have the power not only to self-inflict trauma in the physical carving of possibilities, but to inflict trauma on the sculpted image and on the poem, all the while

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incrementally making present as well as visible a representational reproduction of David and incrementally making materially present but increasingly less visible the representation of its ghost. The looping circularity of the levels of representation reproduces and makes visible the looping circularity of the runs, which further reproduce and make visible the looping circularity of dynamic heterarchy and intermediation. By playing the game of the poem, we bear the responsibilities of enlivening the code object and shaping our mutual identity formation processes.

These multilevel looping circularities and degrees of interpenetration echo Homer's ekphrastic description of the making of the shield of Achilles by Hephaestus in the eighteenth book of the *Iliad*. The shield depicts a series of idyllic and peaceful scenes organized in concentric rings that are described by Homer "in centrifugal order, moving from the innermost circle to the rim" (Heffernan 1993: 12). The shield, however, not only functions as circular representation, it also has the material power of an agent. As suggested by Heffernan, the shield "is metaphorically interchangeable with Achilles himself" (ibid.: 11), and even as it protects Achilles in battle, it is instrumental in his death. Hephaestus makes the shield, yet also feels responsible for sealing Achilles's fate and desires to "hide him away from death and its sorrow / at that time when his hard fate comes upon him" (Homer: 18.466–67; quoted in Heffernan 1993: 11). Although the shield is born of divine power, Achilles's enemies are able to penetrate it in combat and literal gaps in its material representation appear. These absences in form render visible the peaceful life no longer available to Achilles upon creation of the shield. The disturbing nature of the hole in the reality of the shield is that it marks Achilles's negation and makes materially manifest the ontological wounds that representation is able to inflict. This idea finds its poetological reflection in Larsen's poem. The poem's thematic hauntology resides in its own awareness of how it functions as a digital poem—how its Flash file format hides its image files and how its verbal powers of representing the cycles of killing and enlivening in visual media in turn materially animate the ghost of its own represented code-object. Aware of the metaphysical implications of dynamic heterarchy and intermediation, this poem asks itself and us, and in turn we ask the poem: do such procedures trap the soul in stone? Or release it? "When is the real real?" (link 10). When it is flesh? When it is stone? When it is an immaterial body, a gap, a hole? When it is singular? When it converges with other identities or objects across time and space? When Achilles is the shield? When David is David? Regardless of the answers to these questions, the metaphysical consequences are recursive. And as the poem itself argues: "In the end . . . it is only / absence that matters." (link 57)

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Encoding and Decoding the Immaterial Body in Harry Giles's "Photo of Maud Wagner"

While the agentic nature of the code-object suffuses the genre with exciting ontological consequences, as seen above, its mechanical enlivenment process also means it can easily become digital detritus, an obsolete *ephemeron* that cannot be recovered *ex negativo* even as it exists *ex negativo*. The original hardware and software specifications of code-objects are often condemned to obsolescence as technology mutates and develops, so that a large amount of digital poetry produced and published either off- or online has since been relegated to the digital dustbin. This problem is further compounded by the relative frequency with which online magazines and other sites become defunct, either because they have been proactively deleted or are no longer maintained. As a case in point, Harry Giles's "Photo of Maud Wagner" was originally published in 2013 in the online poetry magazine *Verse Kraken*. The magazine was defunct from 2015 until spring of 2017, and its published poetry was unavailable for viewing until recently. *Verse Kraken* commissioned hybrid poetry challenges based on spurs, or material taken

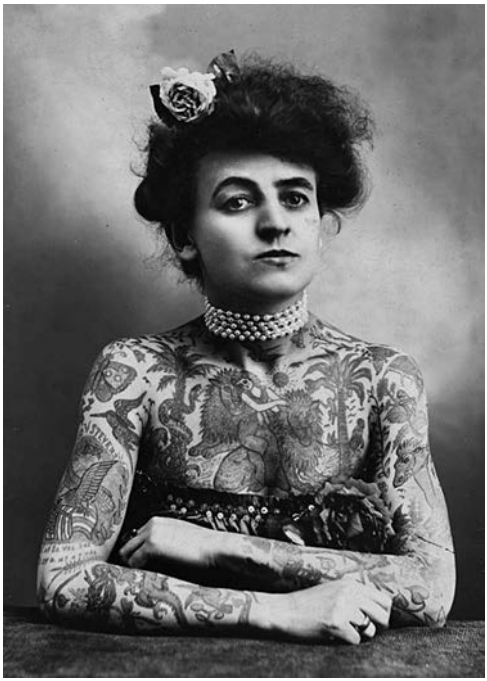

Figure 5 "Portrait of a Woman Showing Images Tattooed or Painted on her Upper Body." Los Angeles, CA: The Plaza Gallery, c1907, *Library of Congress*, www.loc.gov/pictures/item/2006687059/. Public domain

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from the public domain to act as inspiration for its contributors, some of which included the intermedial remediation of copyright-free visual material available on the Internet. Giles's "Photo of Maud Wagner" is one of a group of poems by a handful of poets who submitted their compositions under the rubric "Maud Stevens Wagner (1907)" to accompany the photograph of the famously tattooed Maud Wagner seen in figure 5.

The poem itself consists of this photograph as well as a PDF file (figure 6) whose text is written in a combination of ASCII code and anagrams based on Maud Wagner's name, the typographical arrangement of which recreates the actual concrete image of Maud Wagner as shown in the photograph.

```
++=~~~::~~~~N=a dame wrungD8Z7I+++??IIII
?+==~::::~~=a gnawed rumNNNDZ7I++??II?I
?+==~::::~:~aged maw runNNNNNNZ7?????I?I
??+==~~::::dame raw gunNNNNDNN7+=++??III
II?+=~~~::+=NNNNNO$I?+===7ZNND8+=+????I?
III?===~~::NMNNM8ZN$DN~$OO$NNND?===????I
77I???+=~~=NNNNM8ZDN7Z7,$$INND$?====+???
777III??+==?ZNNNOI~,:?$~:,:rug me a dawn
$$$7777II?+==?NMO$$?=?N7:,,run me a dawg
$$Z$$$$777I??+Z7NOO$7$NDZZ:draw me a gun
ZZZZZZZ$$$7I??+DN8OO$$7=~:~a drag we num
aw damn urge7I?I78DDDDO$7?~~~::~~~~~::~~
am new guard77777ZONND8$+7~::::::~~~::~~
gander aw um$$$8NO?8?II:..+?=::~::~~~~=~
raw nudemag==87ZZDNNNDO7+Z:=+?,,~~~~~===
OOOOOOO77..,,7ZD++7DO?DO,=~:=+7:~I~~~===
OOOOOOZ?~=?:,Inew dum raga=++,?,,+..=~=+
O88OOO~7+,.$:,mug dawn era+.:?.7=:?~~+??
OOOOOO=7$I:??$mudrage wan+I=+??,7+++,?II
OO88OOI7,+$OD$wargame dun7?I.?I=8$,::777
OOO88$$7,,7MN$ZZ7I??+7II$?+I~+7?NOZ=+?$$
8888O?+++=?ND88$$=I+=?7O77?:+?=DN??=:,$Z
8O88Z7+7~~=NNN8DZ$7~778D$I7I?7ZI=$+.+,$Z
8888I77+=7wager mad unDNNNN7NND$$Z,.,,,O
888O7++I++NN,:7dare maw gunDDDODZZO=~:.O
888~+~7Z+M$+.....,.,,?read maw gunO?=:.=
maw gun dearZI~,.=I+:,.:,~,,,+~++?O?:..,
OO??:~==I==+mag wun dear$$7?,:=,,..,.:..
888~,,~I$,I==$.,:=+gawn dear um.,=.~,...
gawn dear umZ,?I=,~+,,...,,,,,....~8Z~,,7
8NNNDNNND8NDNZ$DZ8$7OI,,,::=,maud wagner
```

Figure 6 Harry Giles's poem "Photo of Maud Wagner," 2013. With kind permission by the author

It also consists of a sound file (figure 7) comprising two voices: a highly artificial, digitized female voice that performs the code at an accelerated tempo, and a very sonorous, seductive "analogue" male voice which sounds the anagrams in a slight Midwestern, flatlander twang, echoing Maud Wagner's native roots in Kansas.

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Figure 7 QR code for audio component of Harry Giles's poem "Photo of Maud Wagner," 2013. With kind permission by the author

The gendered performance of these two speakers is of special importance and is anchored so that we have multiple semiotic systems that seem to uncomfortably compete for the attention of the user both internally (on the part of the simultaneous voices) and externally (on the part of the voices in conjunction with the written text). While the user does not generate content, he or she is inexorably ensnared in the paragonal bargaining of which medium or semiotic system or combination thereof is most adept at encoding and decoding Maud Wagner's material and immaterial realities, that is, both her as subject and as self. The poem's gender performance is formally and thematically constituted by the poem's operating procedures and file formats. To produce the coded ASCII text seen in figure 6, the digital reproduction of the photograph in figure 5 was run through an ASCII image generator (Giles 2016). ASCII code is a type of telegraph code, and is thus genetically linked to Morse code, codeveloped by and named after Samuel F. B. Morse, who coinvented the telegraph and operated his own daguerreotype studio beginning in 1840 (Dinius 2012: 1–25). The use of ASCII code thus creates an important historical and conceptual framework for conceiving the material imprint of light on chemically treated surfaces as code. Maud Wagner's name was run through the Internet Anagram Server, and the resulting anagrams were manually chosen from a long list and pasted into the ASCII text to create the unified written text (Giles 2016). The original ASCII text was run through a text-to-voice generator to produce the synthesized female performance of ASCII text, while the male performance is a self-recording by Giles that they then layered on top of the text-to-voice output (the poet refers to themself using the pronouns *they* and *them*; Giles 2016). The typographical arrangement of text corresponds to the gendered performance of the voices

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such that the written ASCII code—a functional code that represents a kind of pseudo-code, insofar as it cannot reproduce Wagner—reads as female, while the anagrams read as male. Together they reproduce the image of the photo of Maud Wagner, meaning that their multimodality is dually gendered, and their work, in tandem, not only makes this a concrete poem, but also creates a meta-picture that reinstates and critiques the gender and semiotic binary so often associated with poetry and visual art. This binary is based on long-standing cultural values which have, over the course of centuries, been repeatedly reified and which serve as a theoretical springboard for much of W. J. T. Mitchell's early hypothesizing on the reality of images and the nature of ekphrasis.

Mitchell cites Edmund Burke as a forerunner to this type of thinking, but it is Gotthold Ephraim Lessing's monumental work that systematizes a number of other features associated with visual systems of art versus verbal ones (Mitchell 1986: 110–11). In Lessing's configuration, visual art is composed of natural signs, based on imitation, concerned with the body, limited to the external, bounded by space, ruled by the gaze and not surprisingly gendered female. Poetry is composed of arbitrary signs, based on expression, concerned with the mind, expanded to the internal, bounded by time, ruled by the ear and of course gendered male (ibid.: 110). Yet, as a meta-picture, "The Photo of Maud Wagner" entangles and inverts many of these relations. It does so by reenacting them only to then comment on how the tattoos, which are visual representations, inscribe Maud Wagner's body and encode her gender performance, while also commenting on its own reinscribing, relettering, and reencoding of both this image and her body via its remediation procedures. By doing so, it incidentally invokes the curious language of Renaissance emblem theory, which conceives the graphic image as a "body" and the motto as the "soul" (Caldwell 2000: 277–86). The tattoos are both visual representation and code, so they give the impression of being able to speak on her body and for her soul. However, the interpolation of the anagrams into the ASCII code obscures or makes absent Wagner's original tattoos; yet, like those tattoos, the anagrams and the ASCII code have the uncanny effect of creating a palimpsestic ghosting across the materialized body of the visual poem. Because we conceive of the photograph as being encoded within the poem and Maud Wagner as being encoded within the photograph and by the tattoos, this ghosting seems to also traverse Maud Wagner's immaterialized body.

Within the temporal performance of the poem, we have a further degree of complication. The ventriloquized male voice slowly and casually strokes Maud Wagner's anagrammatic sensuality until the poem comes to its visual end, but the synthetic female voice that scans her own coded lines with a

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pinched, volatile velocity only gets as far as the first set of three question marks in line 7, the line in which the code meets the concrete, digital image's eyes (see figure 6). The male voice, layered on top of the female voice in the generative process of the poem and embodied as the naming agent forming her identity and speaking for her "self," verbally performs the male gaze until the poem comes to its visual end. The code, in contrast, is gendered and embodied as female and stops at the poem's representation of the photo's representation of the eyes of Maud Wagner. Her eyes are thus present but not visible. This is the moment in which the poem encounters itself as well as the photograph, and it is the moment when the meta-picture asks: what does this photo want from me, what does Maud Wagner want from this photo, what do we want from Maud Wagner, and what want do we want from this poem? This is the moment in which organized epistemology, represented here as visual and verbal form, questions its ability to touch and to reproduce an otherwise invisible or absent self or ontology.

Roland Barthes, in *Camera Lucida*, famously theorized the metaphysical realities of the photographic subject:

> I call "photographic referent" not the *optionally* real thing to which an image or a sign refers but the *necessarily* real thing which has been placed before the lens, without which there would be no photograph. Painting can feign reality without having seen it. Discourse combines signs which have referents, of course, but these referents can be and are most often "chimeras." Contrary to these imitations, in Photography I can never deny that *the thing has been there*. There is a superimposition here: of reality and of the past. (2000 [1980]: 76)

This leads Barthes to argue that photography is asymbolic, that it cannot be reduced to cultural or political codes made miraculously accessible via the decoding procedures of what he calls the *studium* (ibid.: 51); rather, as I like to phrase it for myself, its ontology is accessible through phenomenological reasoning, that is, through the embodied encounter with the object. This encounter is established by what he calls the *punctum*, the wound that "pricks" and "bruises" the viewer and tethers him or her in direct contact with, in Barthes's case, the photographic subject (ibid.: 27).

In our case, however, this poem argues that the photograph's *punctum* may be the eyes, but that its own *punctum*, when understood in terms of its concrete visual form, is the series of three question marks in line 7, and when understood in terms of its temporality, is the repeated, dialogical act of questioning. Because it is a poem and an enlivened meta-picture, it can recognize and voice its own *punctum*, but paradoxically, it does this via written and verbal code, in other words, through its *studium*. In this poem, dynamic heterarchy and its highly transparent operating procedures work

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so that the poem is both *punctum* and *studium*, and the photographic referent is both "the *optionally* real thing" and "the *necessarily* real thing." At this moment in which epistemology questions its ability to touch and to reproduce ontology, the visceral understanding, the pain of the *punctum*, is the recognition on the part of the poem that the code, whichever code it is, whether functional, pseudo-, or gendered, would appear to move in only one direction. We can read the poem, the poem can read itself and we can both read the photo and her tattoos, but this does not mean that we can read Maud Wagner. The photo may encounter Maud Wagner, the poem may encounter the photo, and we may encounter the poem, but none of these encounters can with ontological fidelity reproduce Maud Wagner. We can look at the representation of her palimpsestic soul but she cannot look back. It is, in this sense, an elegiac poem that adopts the voice of someone that has come before to question and criticize the legitimacy of the poetic act of ventriloquism, especially as a male voice speaking for the silenced female image. Yet as soon as the *punctum* is made verbally manifest, we understand how this series of remediation procedures works and we have empathy for the poem's desire to touch, hear, and see Maud Wagner. Upon doing so, we enter the dialogic of the poem, the code moves polydirectionally, we become intermediated agent-actants, and we see the code-object's verbalized, material representations of Maud Wagner's ontological absence. We have a multimodal, embodied encounter, and we become part of an emergent structure of vertically and horizontally corresponding ontological events that are both synchronic and diachronic: it is the closest we can get to Maud Wagner, to the photo, and to the poem, and it is the closest the poem can get to itself.

Concluding the Ending of the Beginning

The readings offered here of Deena Larsen's "Carving in Possibilities" (2001) and Harry Giles's "Photo of Maud Wagner" (2013) suggest that a digital poetry of ekphrasis, when considered in light of dynamic heterarchy and intermediation, of both representational and experiential reasoning, is possible. The result is a kind of Pygmalion poetics: a poetics that uses and also exploits the interstice between modalities, the interstice between systems of mediation, and the interstice between "lifelikeness" and material ontology. It is also a type of ekphrasis that is willfully metaphysical in tone and content, capable of speculatively investigating the relations of mind and matter, time and space, and the material and immaterial realities of code, computer-mediated poetry, images, and human-computer interaction. It is further a poetics of intermediation, aware of its capacity to forge what appears as a unified image, an image that can appear to be magically entered, but is also

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aware of the phenomenological shaping power of the embodied user. It even appears to be a poetics capable of fulfilling Richard Powers's desire for a kind of digital representation able "to refresh us to the irreducible complexity of the analog world, a complexity whose scale and heft we might always have underestimated, without the shortfall of its ghostly imitations" (2000: n.p.). And it is certainly a poetics that would not argue against the possibility of ekphrasis but would encode ekphrasis as nothing other than possibility.

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